

RICHARD C. McCLANEY

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PROFESSIONAL SUMMARY

Strategic program leader with 15+ years of experience driving operational excellence, cross-functional orchestration, and technology-enabled transformation across retail and technology organizations. Proven track record managing large-scale initiatives for Fortune 50/500 companies, aligning strategic planning with execution, and leveraging AI-driven workflows to enhance organizational capability. Experienced in influencing senior leadership (VP/CIO level), implementing repeatable processes, and serving as the organizational glue across business and technical teams.

EXPERIENCE

Sr. Strategic Projects Lead, EKW | Turing

Jan 2026 – Present

- Lead multiple cross-functional teams of domain experts executing strategic AI model validation initiatives, orchestrating complex evaluation programs on real-world agentic retail tasks requiring 7–10 hours of sustained effort per task cycle.
- Partnered cross-functionally with engineering to define program requirements and implement standardized evaluation rubrics (100-200 criteria), establishing data-driven scoring methodology (automated + human-expert) to measure and communicate model performance results to leadership.
- Directed end-to-end quality assurance processes and operational cadence, defining benchmark standards and driving team adherence to performance metrics (AHT targets), serving as the *connective tissue* between domain experts and program leadership.
- Contributed to the design of AI-driven reinforcement learning workflows, helping architect an RL training environment that enhanced model optimization within the evaluation pipeline — demonstrating bias for action on emerging technical initiatives.
- Designed and deployed a scalable change management and onboarding program — including training materials, reference guides, and hands-on enablement — reducing new expert ramp-up time.

Manager, Retail Technology Consulting | Ernst & Young

Aug 2023 – Nov 2025

- Developed AI training content (EY.q) on Blue Yonder modules, leveraging AI-driven workflows to accelerate system-specific implementation responses and transform organizational capability in retail technology consulting.
- Drove strategic planning and execution of the *Operational Excellence* workstream for a Fortune 50 retail pharmacy chain, delivering a \$1.5B inventory reduction initiative through data-driven metrics design and streamlined operational processes.
- Evaluated, designed, and optimized cloud-based technology solutions aligned with enterprise merchandising goals, driving repeatable implementation processes across client engagements.
- Drove cross-functional PMO (hybrid-agile model) and implementation of Blue Yonder merchandising solutions for Fortune 500 client across four product areas — orchestrating functional design workshops and balancing customization vs. standardization.
- Led strategic planning workshops with C-suite stakeholders (CIO) at a leading Fortune 500 retailer to define technology roadmaps aligned with enterprise goals, anticipating organizational needs 2–3 quarters ahead to drive proactive decision-making.
- Designed and delivered change management programs for client teams on category management technology, achieving 100% adoption rate and measurable improvements in operational efficiency.
- Managed end-to-end program governance across multiple client engagements — from requirements definition and vendor selection (RFP creation) through risk analysis, testing, training, and rollout.

Head of Merchandising | Fresh Street

Oct 2021 – Nov 2022

Startup acquired — led merchandising strategy across e-commerce and brick & mortar channels.

- Developed end-to-end merchandising strategy, defining strategic priorities for customer acquisition and retention post-launch across digital and physical channels.
- Defined and implemented repeatable processes for planogram rollouts — including assortment changes, pricing promotions, and calendar-driven activities — driving operational standardization.
- Orchestrated cross-functional partnerships with startups and established platforms (Uber Eats, Dwell Social) to launch new service offerings and expand market presence.
- Developed technology implementation strategy for merchandising systems, maximizing ERP efficiency and aligning software capabilities with business growth objectives.
- Leveraged data-driven insights and A/B testing to continuously improve digital conversion, using metrics to determine improvements and inform strategic decisions.

Manager of Program Management | Amazon

Mar 2019 – Oct 2021

- Led strategic 'Buy v. Build' analysis for Amazon Go Convenience, presenting data-driven recommendations to senior leadership that identified 16 dev-years' worth of savings by integrating all Amazon brick & mortar formats onto Blue Yonder.
- Led Amazon Go Convenience's Merchandising Department — building, managing, and scaling a team of 8 managers while driving organizational alignment across cross-functional tech and non-tech teams.

- Introduced ‘Planogram Standardization’ methodology — implementing repeatable processes and driving automation that saved 200+ labor hours annually while enabling scalable operational standards.
- Established weekly business rhythm (revision calendar) to streamline planogram changes by category, reducing store labor by 8% through data-driven process optimization.

Senior Manager, Business Insights | Red Bull

May 2016 – May 2018

- Drove strategic market analysis and data-driven insights across 15+ national accounts/divisions, managing and communicating results to senior leadership to enhance market presence and shelf space position.
- Fostered a culture of curiosity and continuous improvement, mentoring 3 direct reports while driving cross-functional collaboration across sales and category management teams.

EARLIER EXPERIENCE

Merchandising Manager Harbor Freight Tools	May 2014 – May 2016
Manager, Space & Presentation Target	Nov 2012 – May 2014
Business Analyst / Sr. Business Analyst (NSO) Target	Jun 2010 – Nov 2012

EDUCATION

Bachelor of Science in Business & Administration, Marketing	2009
Southern Illinois University – Carbondale	

SKILLS & TOOLS

Program & Project Management: Strategic Planning, Cross-Functional Orchestration, PMO (Hybrid-Agile), Change Management, Stakeholder Management, Business Rhythm / Cadence Design, Vendor Selection (RFP)

Technology & Platforms: Blue Yonder (Category Management), JIRA, Confluence, Oracle Netsuite, Apollo Space Planning, SQL, AWS (foundational), AI/ML Evaluation Frameworks

Data & Analytics: IRI, Nielsen, Numerator, Mintel | Syndicated Data, Market Analysis, KPI Design, A/B Testing

Productivity: Microsoft Excel (Advanced), PowerPoint, Access, Photoshop, AutoCAD